

H1 2026 INDUSTRY REPORT

H1 2026 Report: China's Beauty Market Analysis

China's beauty market is not shrinking. It is relocating.

China's beauty products across channels, down the price ladder, through the promotional calendar and into the products that grew in the first half of 2026, from observed online sales across three of China's largest marketplaces, 2022 to mid-2026.

Moojing Market Research Team
September 2026

MOOJING
Market Intelligence

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

Every sales figure in this report is observed online sales across three of China's largest marketplaces, modelled from listings and captured prices. It is not the size of China's beauty market (i.e., it excludes physical stores & several other marketplaces). Marketplaces are anonymised throughout and grouped by how demand is generated, as *content-led* and *established marketplace* commerce.

We define *Premium* products as products with unit prices between **CN¥ 360-1,080** (~US$ 50-150), applied identically to every segment and marketplace. *Luxury* tier products are items above CN¥ 1,080.

Beauty products refers to skincare, colour cosmetics and fragrance unless a chart says otherwise. Chapter 4 measures product benefits by the words in product titles, so a figure for "anti-acne" is the sales of skincare products whose titles mention it, and because one title can name several benefits, those figures overlap. Social listening is a separate and shorter dataset: it begins in January 2024, covers three social platforms, and measures posts and interactions (the volume of posts is sometimes called buzz, 声量), not purchases.

Fuller notes on method and limits are in the appendix.

Executive summary

China's online beauty market has largely held its size through the trade tensions of 2025, but the way consumers spend within it has changed considerably over the past four years, and in the first half of 2026 they have been asking more of every product they buy, so where the money now sits, and what it is spent on, calls for a fresh look at channel, price and product strategy.

CN¥ 434.8 billion

observed online beauty sales across three marketplaces, 2025

+3.4% on 2024, after a trough in 2024

55%

of beauty sales flowed through content-led commerce, January-July 2026

28% in 2022

+26.5%

growth in skincare products sold on an anti-acne claim, H1 2026 on H1 2025

against **−1.0%** for all skincare

01 **The category held its size, but changed its shape.** Sales went from **CN¥ 444.6 billion** in 2022 to **CN¥ 434.8 billion** in 2025 after bottoming out in 2024, and the entire decline came from skincare, while colour cosmetics, fragrance and tools grew **+18.8%** over the same three years. Growth has continued into 2026, although at about a third of last year's rate. [Chapter 1]

02 **Sales have moved to content-led commerce, and the promotional months still decide the year.** Content-led commerce rose from **28%** to **55%** of the three-marketplace total, January-July, and the peak moved to October, but the four promotional months still carry two-fifths of annual sales, with premium's share **+4.2 points** higher inside them. [Chapter 2]

03 **Skincare shoppers are trading down, while colour cosmetics and fragrance are trading up.** Since 2023, mass-priced skincare has grown while both price bands above it fell, and in the first half of 2026 premium skincare fell **−11.6%** while luxury skincare recovered, growing **+9.1%**. In colour cosmetics, lip and eye products moved up the price ladder while face products did not. [Chapter 3]

04 **Inside a flat skincare category, products that promise a specific result are growing.** Skincare sold on an anti-acne claim grew **+26.5%** and face make-up **+13.6%** in the first half of 2026, and in both cases the growth came from content-led commerce. [Chapter 4]

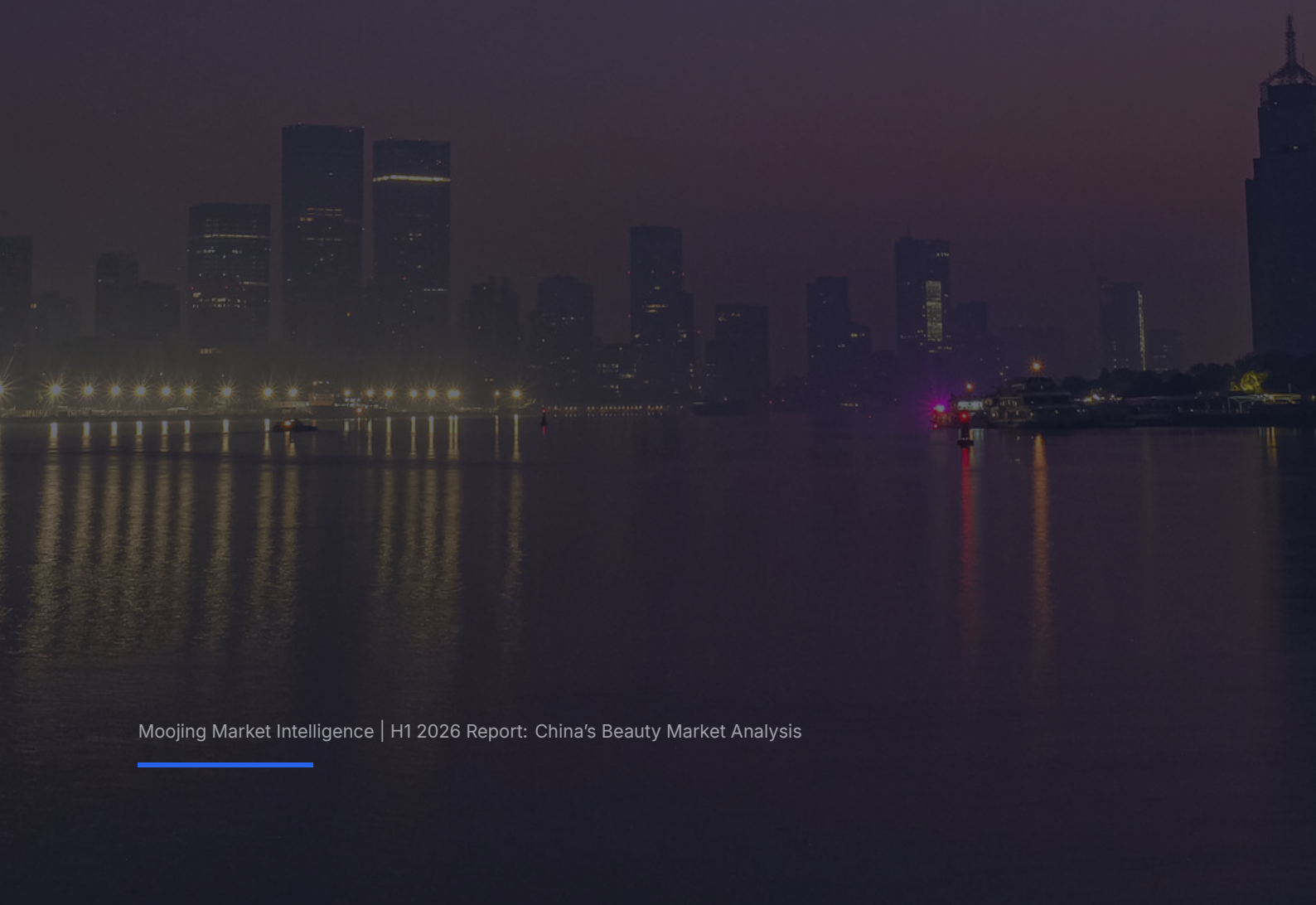
05 **Whose premium it is depends on the channel, and value-seeking conversation has a home of its own.** International brands take two-thirds of sampled premium skincare sales on established marketplaces and Chinese brands four-fifths on content-led commerce. In social conversation, which is measured separately from sales, talk of cheaper substitutes happens almost entirely on RED (小红书), which also carries half of the conversation about acne. [Chapters 3 and 5]

What we recommend, in brief, is that brands time premium launches into the promotional windows; choose product direction one segment at a time; build for content-led commerce, where both the growth and the Chinese premium brands are; treat RED as the value-seeking channel; and build products around a specific, visible result, as Chapter 6 sets out.

01

The market in 2026

The market bottomed out in 2024 and has recovered slowly since, with growth in 2026 running at about a third of last year's pace and most of it coming from colour cosmetics and fragrance.

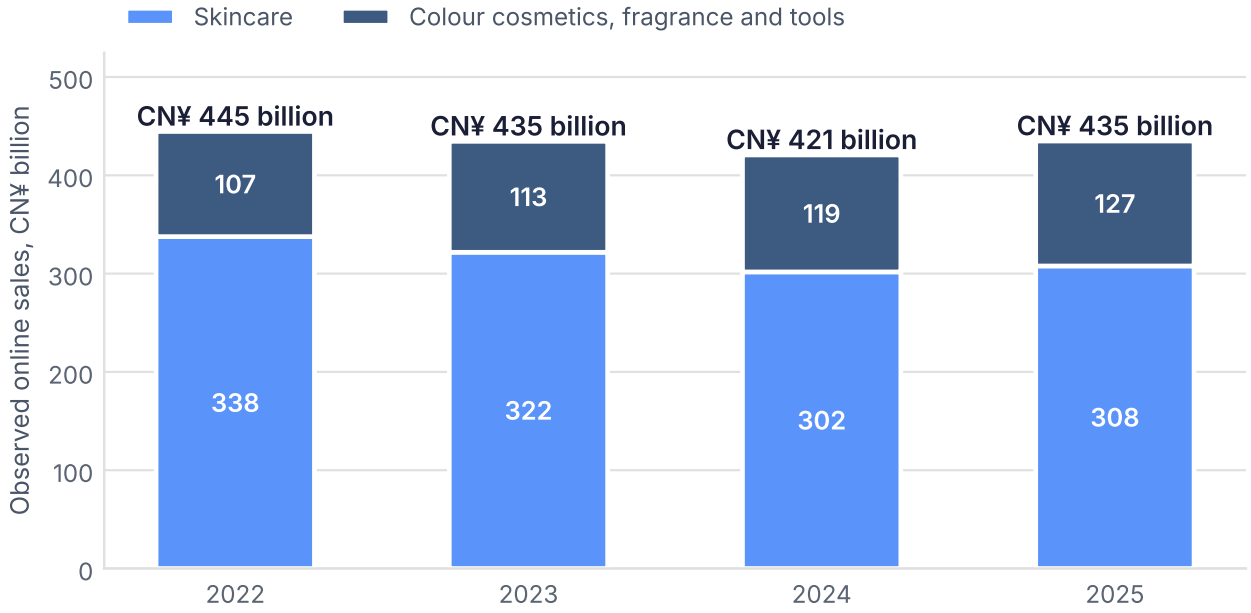


A category that held its size

Despite the trade-war escalations of 2025, China's online beauty category has largely held steady. Across three of China's largest online marketplaces, sales went from **CN¥ 444.6 billion** in 2022 to **CN¥ 434.8 billion** in 2025, a **−2.2%** decline over three years, after bottoming out at **CN¥ 420.7 billion** in 2024 and posting a **+3.4%** recovery the following year. That three-year decline is almost entirely down to skincare, which fell **−8.8%** across 2022-2025, while colour cosmetics, fragrance and beauty tools grew **+18.8%** over the same period.

EXHIBIT 1

The category troughed in 2024, and the whole decline is skincare



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, whole beauty category by year, CN¥ billion. Not the total market.

Note: Segment totals are inside the bars.

Why the mix has shifted is hard to prove from sales data alone, but we believe Chinese consumers have become more deliberate about how they buy, researching for longer, waiting for the promotional windows and comparing more before they commit, and that brands are leaning towards local sourcing and local product development, which they can control, rather than towards imported lines that are exposed to cross-border and tariff conditions, which they cannot.

How the three segments performed

Measured across the three core segments, all three grew in 2025, bringing the combined total to **CN¥ 416.4 billion** (**US$ 57.9 billion** at the 2025 average rate), **+3.5%** on 2024. Fragrance grew fastest, at **+18.3%**, rebounding in 2025 from a dip the year before, although it remains less than a twentieth the size of skincare.

EXHIBIT 2

Observed online sales by segment, three marketplaces combined

Segment	2024 (CN¥ billion)	2025 (CN¥ billion)	2025 (US$ billion)	Growth
Skincare	301.72	307.77	42.82	+2.0%
Colour cosmetics	89.08	95.11	13.23	+6.8%
Fragrance	11.46	13.56	1.89	+18.3%
Combined	**402.26**	**416.44**	**57.94**	**+3.5%**

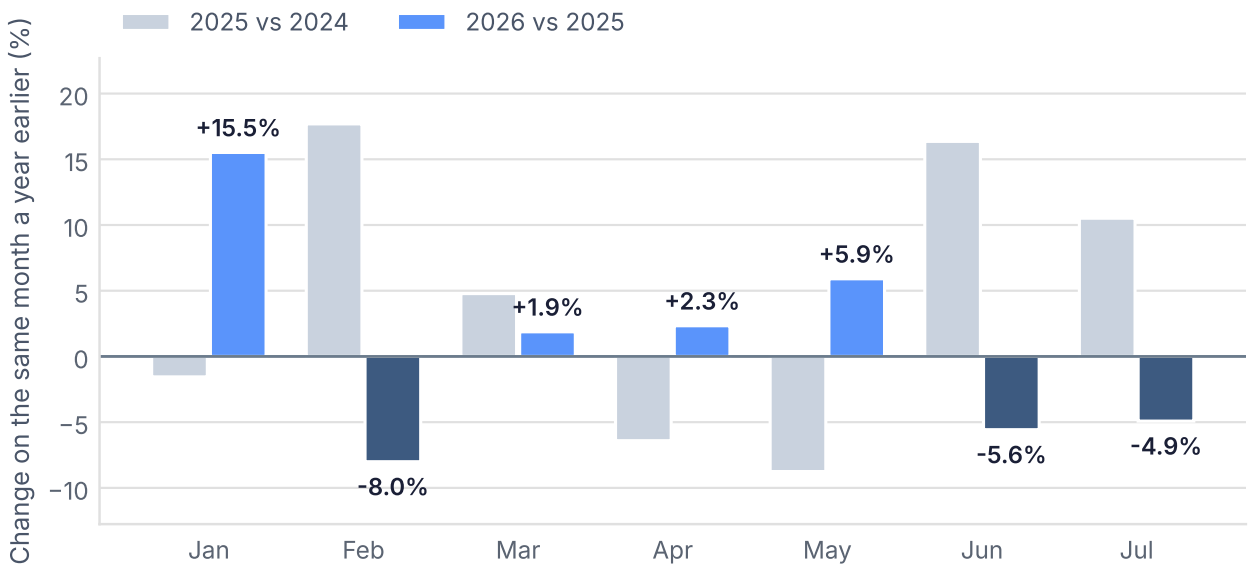
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces. Combined is skincare, colour cosmetics and fragrance only; beauty tools sit outside it, which is why this total is below the whole-category figure above. US$ at the 2025 annual average of 7.1874 CN¥/US$ (European Central Bank reference rate).

2026 so far

Over the first seven months of 2026, the whole category grew **+1.1%** against the same period of 2025, down from **+3.6%** when 2025 is measured the same way against 2024. Growth has not stopped exactly, but it has thinned to about a third of last year's rate. January's **+15.5%** owes much to the timing of Lunar New Year, since January and February together grew **+3.5%**, and three of the six months after January were negative.

EXHIBIT 3

2026 opened strongly and has thinned since



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, whole beauty category, each month against the same month a year earlier. One marketplace's 2026 series is joined across a category restructure; see the appendix.

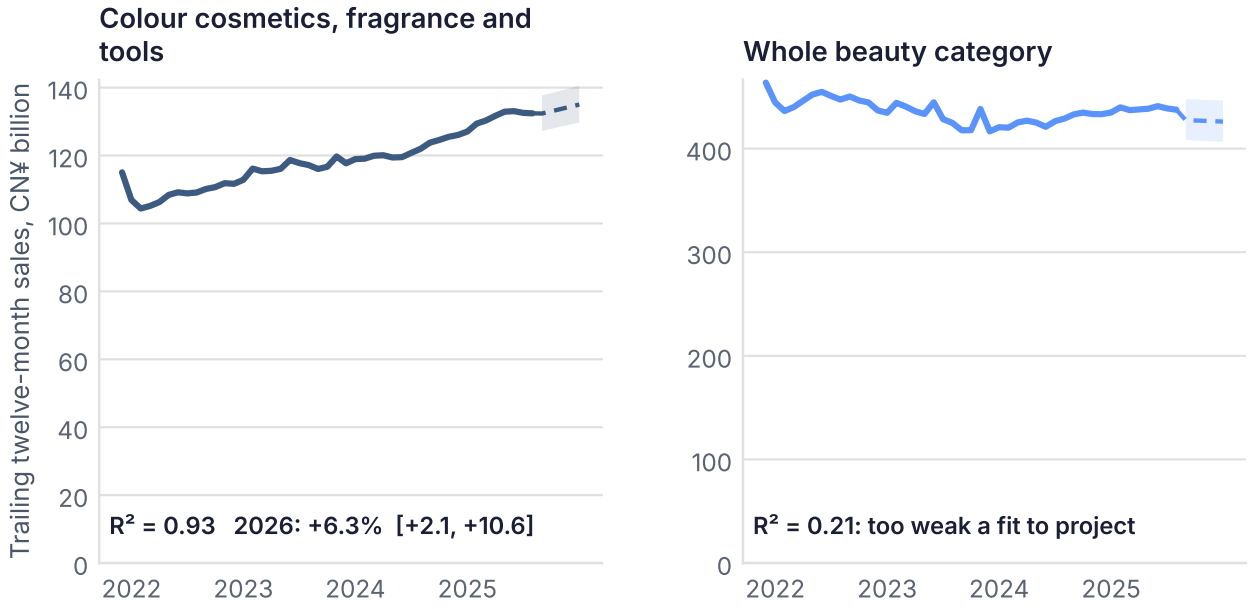
What the trend suggests for the rest of 2026

To see what the trend supports for the rest of the year, we fitted a log-linear trend to trailing twelve-month sales across **45** windows ending July 2026 and projected it five months ahead with a **95%**

prediction interval. For colour cosmetics, fragrance and tools, the fit explains **93%** of the variance and puts 2026 growth between **+2.1%** and **+10.6%** on 2025, which makes this the part of the market we are most optimistic about this year, whereas for the whole category the same fit explains only **21%** of the variance, so rather than quote a projection we rely on the year-to-date figure above.

EXHIBIT 4

The trend points to growth in colour cosmetics and fragrance, but not for the whole category



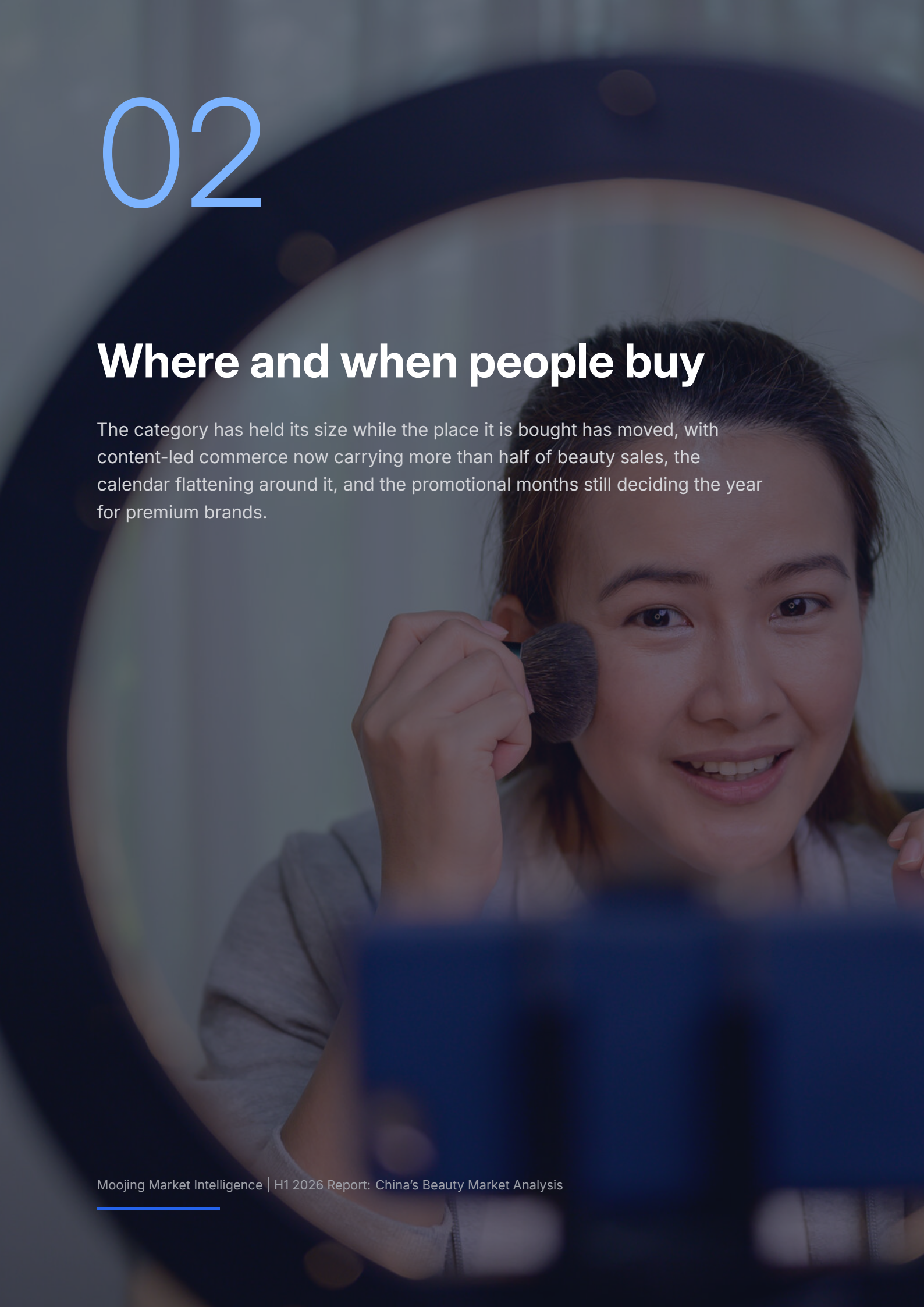
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces. Log-linear fit on 45 trailing twelve-month windows to July 2026, projected to December 2026, 95% prediction interval shaded. R^2 and the implied 2026 growth on 2025 are printed on each panel.

Beauty tools and men's facial care are often suggested as the places where the growth has gone, but across the three marketplaces both were flat, with beauty tools going from **CN¥ 12.8 billion** in 2024 to **CN¥ 12.6 billion** in 2025 and men's facial care from **CN¥ 6.2 billion** to **CN¥ 6.1 billion**.

02

Where and when people buy

The category has held its size while the place it is bought has moved, with content-led commerce now carrying more than half of beauty sales, the calendar flattening around it, and the promotional months still deciding the year for premium brands.

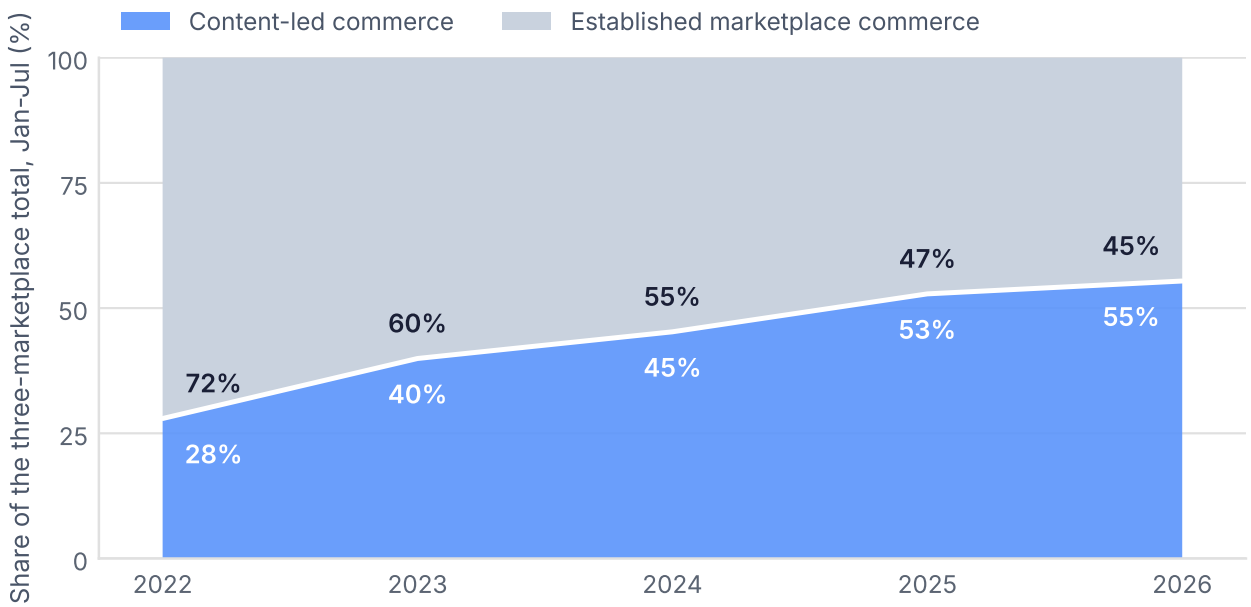


From established marketplaces to content-led commerce

Moojing does not cover offline retail of any kind, whether footfall, store counts or offline sales. Within the online marketplaces, however, the picture is a clear one, and it shows a retail scene that is relocating rather than shrinking. Measured like-for-like on January to July of each year, content-led commerce grew from **28%** of the three-marketplace beauty total in 2022 to **55%** in 2026, while established marketplace commerce fell from **72%** to **45%**, with the two crossing over in 2025.

EXHIBIT 5

Content-led commerce grew from 28% to 55% of beauty sales



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data. Marketplaces are anonymised and grouped by how demand is generated, not by name. January-July of each year.

It is often assumed that brands are pulling back from content-led platforms because of the heavy discounting there, but our data do not reflect that shift as of yet. This relatively new channel took the largest share of beauty sales in a very short time. We believe brands are still watching it closely and re-examining the margins they make there rather than walking away.

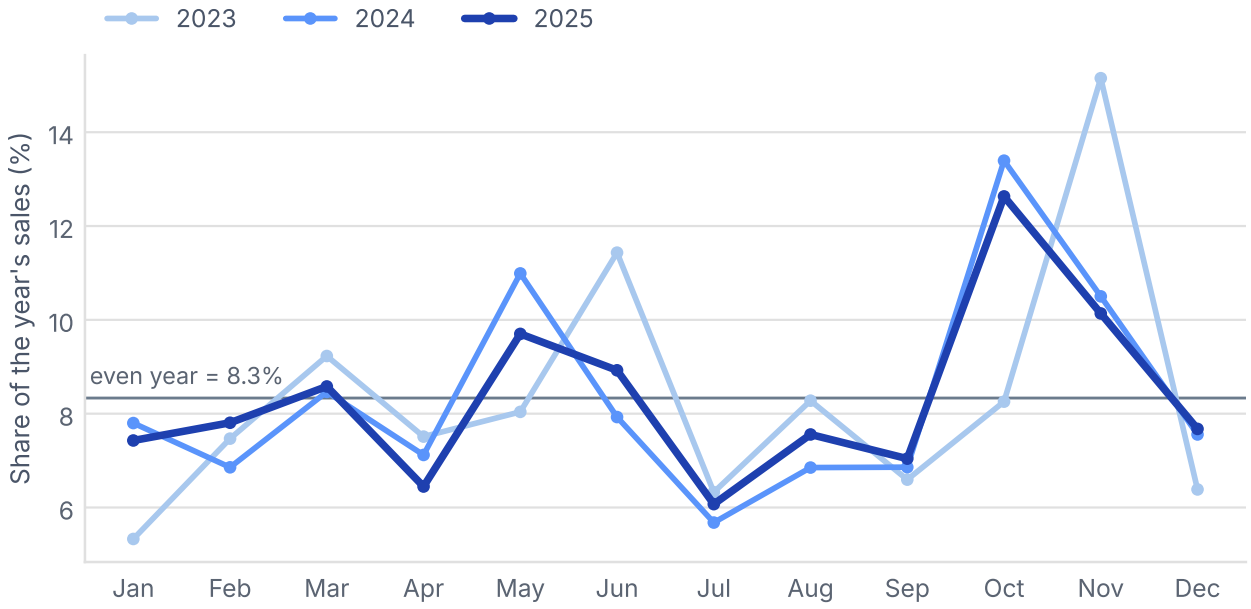
> The channel beauty sales are moving to rewards a different price point.
>
> — Moojing Market Research Team

The shopping calendar

The calendar has shifted as well. In 2023, November carried **15.2%** of the year's sales and was the largest month by some distance, but in 2024 the peak moved to October, at **13.4%**, as the Double 11 pre-sale pulled demand forward, and it stayed there in 2025 at **12.6%**. Over the same period, the gap between the biggest and smallest months narrowed from **9.8 points** to **6.6**, which suggests consumers are spreading their purchases more evenly across the year than they used to.

EXHIBIT 6

The peak moved from November to October and the year flattened

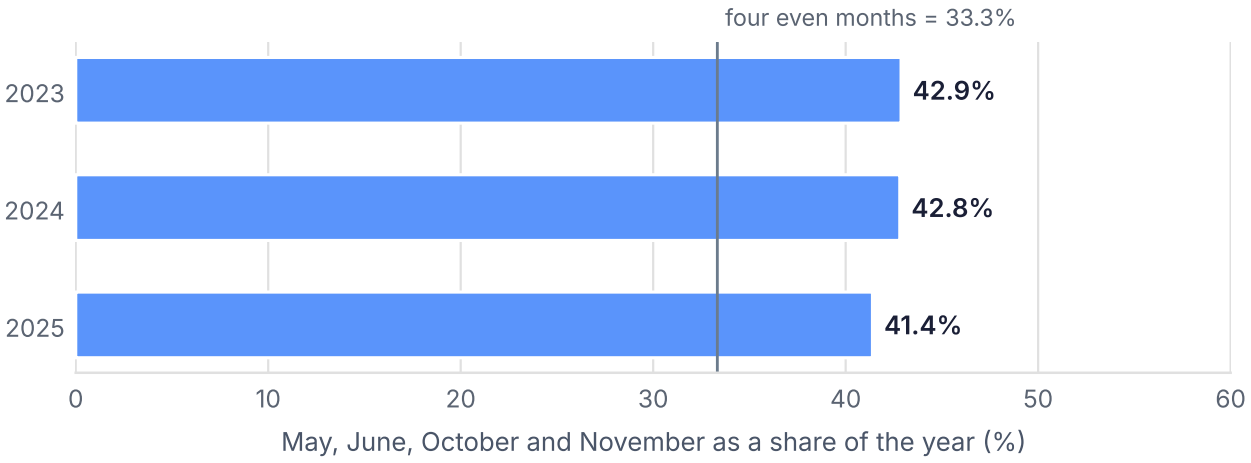


Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, whole beauty category, share of each year's sales by calendar month.

That flattening does not mean promotions matter less. The four months that hold the two big shopping festivals and their pre-sales, May, June, October and November, carried **42.9%**, **42.8%** and **41.4%** of annual sales in 2023, 2024 and 2025 respectively, so the peak has spread out across the promotional bloc without ever leaving it, and any read of the market taken outside those months is effectively measuring the trough.

EXHIBIT 7

Four months still carry two-fifths of the year



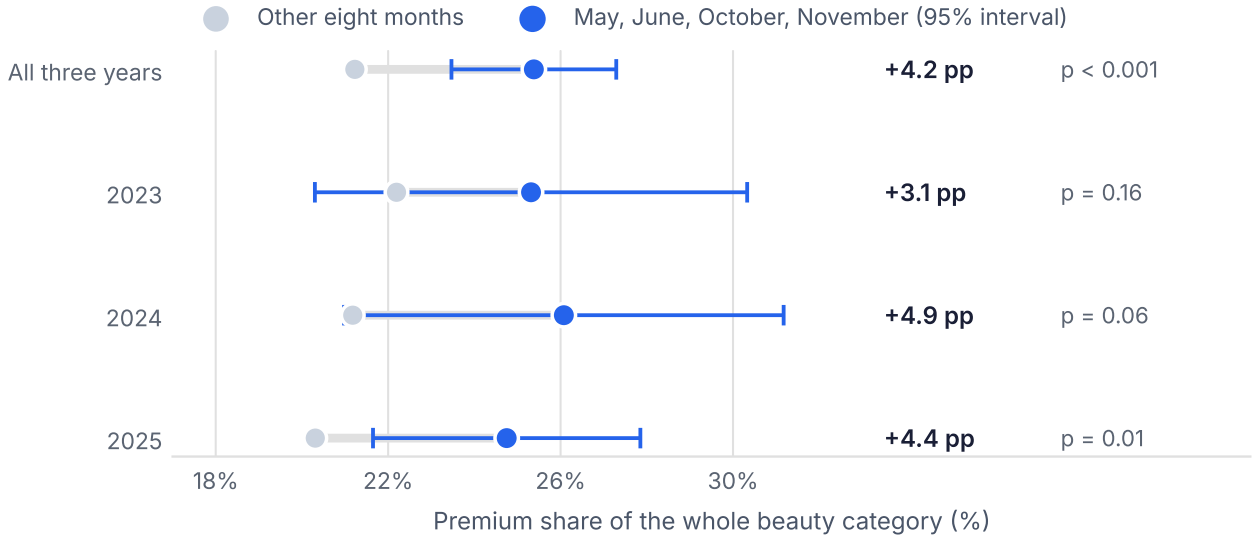
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, whole beauty category. The promotional bloc is May, June, October and November.

Premium in the promotional months

Discounting on China's online marketplaces is widespread, and we do not dispute the reporting on it, but what we do not see in the data is any sign that festival discounting has hurt the premium end of the market. Across the promotional bloc, premium's share of the whole beauty category is **+4.2 points** higher than in the other eight months, at **25.4%** against **21.2%**, and the gap has been positive in all three years we observe, at **+3.1** in 2023, **+4.9** in 2024 and **+4.4** in 2025. During the bloc, the mass tier's share moves **−8.3 points** while both bands above it gain, luxury by **+4.1** as well as premium, which argues against the most obvious alternative explanation, that luxury items are simply being discounted down into the premium band, although it cannot exclude some movement of that kind.

EXHIBIT 8

Premium takes a bigger share of the category in the promotional months



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data, three online marketplaces, 2023-2025, whole beauty category. Promotional months are May, June, October and November. The interval is a 95% Welch interval on the difference between the four and the eight monthly shares; the test is described in the appendix.

The data can show the change in mix but not the intent behind it, which is why we describe the finding as premium taking a bigger share of sales rather than as shoppers trading up. We believe, all the same, that Chinese consumers are treating festival discounts as an opportunity to upgrade their beauty purchases. Nor is the result an artefact of inflated festival list prices: re-running a Double 11 month with coupons fully deducted moves premium's share by only **−0.17 points**, an order of magnitude too little to produce the gap, as the coupon test in the appendix shows.

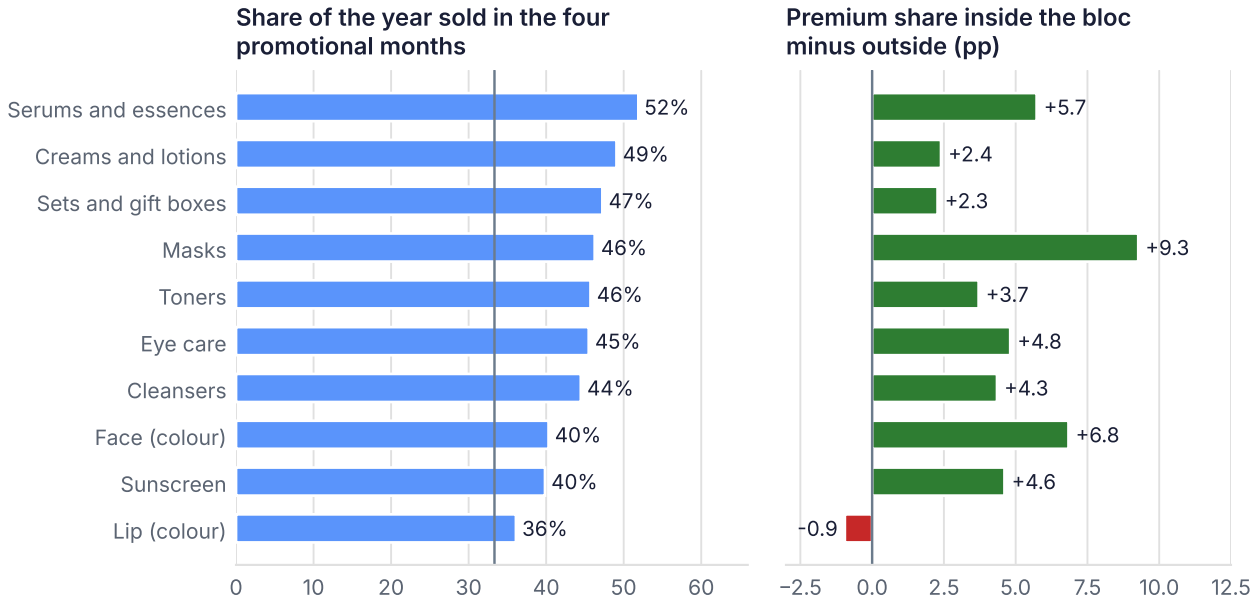
Which products rely most on the promotional months, and which slump afterwards

The bloc matters more for some products than for others. Serums and essences take **52%** of their annual sales in the four months, the most of any function, against **36%** for lip colour, and averaged over the three years, premium's in-bloc gain is positive for every skincare function, from **+2.3 points** for gift sets to **+9.3** for masks, while lip colour is the one product where the promotional months do not lift the premium share. The cost comes in the month after: in most skincare functions, July sales run **20-42%** below the April-May run-in and December sales **18-**

51% below September-October, so a launch timed into the bloc meets a shopper who is ready to upgrade, whereas a launch timed just after it meets a much quieter market.

EXHIBIT 9

Serums lean hardest on the bloc, and premium gains inside it for every skincare function

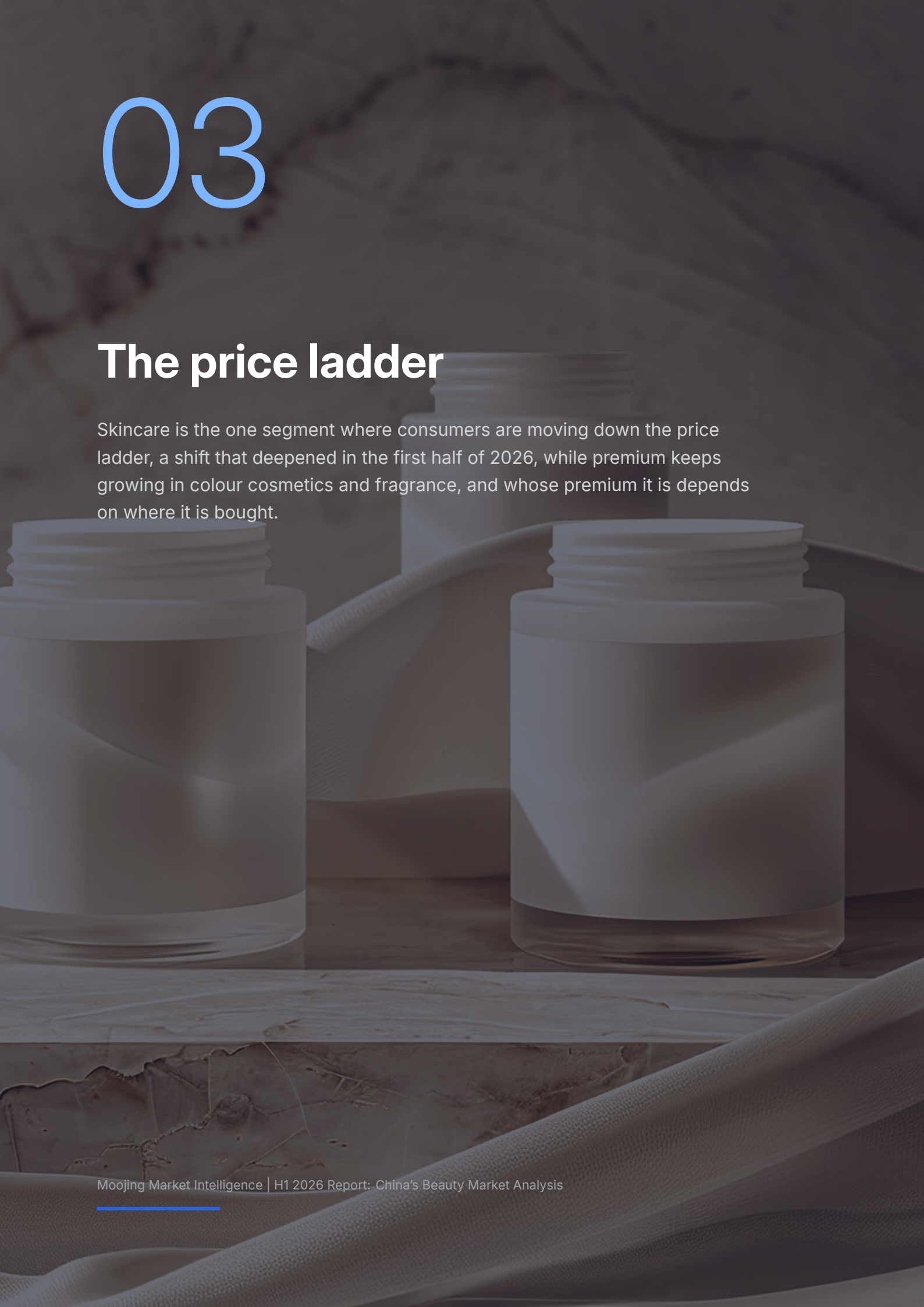


Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data, functions matched across the marketplaces that carry them, 2023-2025 means. Left: share of the function’s annual sales in May, June, October and November. Right: premium share of the function inside the bloc minus outside it.

03

The price ladder

Skincare is the one segment where consumers are moving down the price ladder, a shift that deepened in the first half of 2026, while premium keeps growing in colour cosmetics and fragrance, and whose premium it is depends on where it is bought.



Premium by segment

Consumers are shifting down the price ladder in skincare, and in skincare alone. From 2024 to 2025, premium skincare fell **−6.4%** while the skincare category as a whole grew **+2.0%**, underperforming it by more than eight points, whereas premium colour cosmetics grew **+14.7%** against a category at **+6.8%**, and premium fragrance grew **+15.6%** against a category at **+18.3%**. Adding the segments together does show total premium spend falling, but only because skincare accounts for ~**78%** of all premium beauty spend and drags the total down with it, and measured by half-year, skincare is the only segment whose premium sales are still falling.

EXHIBIT 10

Premium sales by segment, 2025, with growth on 2024

Premium segment	2024 (CN¥ billion)	2025 (CN¥ billion)	2025 (US$ billion)	Growth	Share of category
Skincare	80.11	75.01	10.44	−6.4%	24.4%
Colour cosmetics	14.72	16.87	2.35	+14.7%	17.7%
Fragrance	4.02	4.64	0.65	+15.6%	34.2%

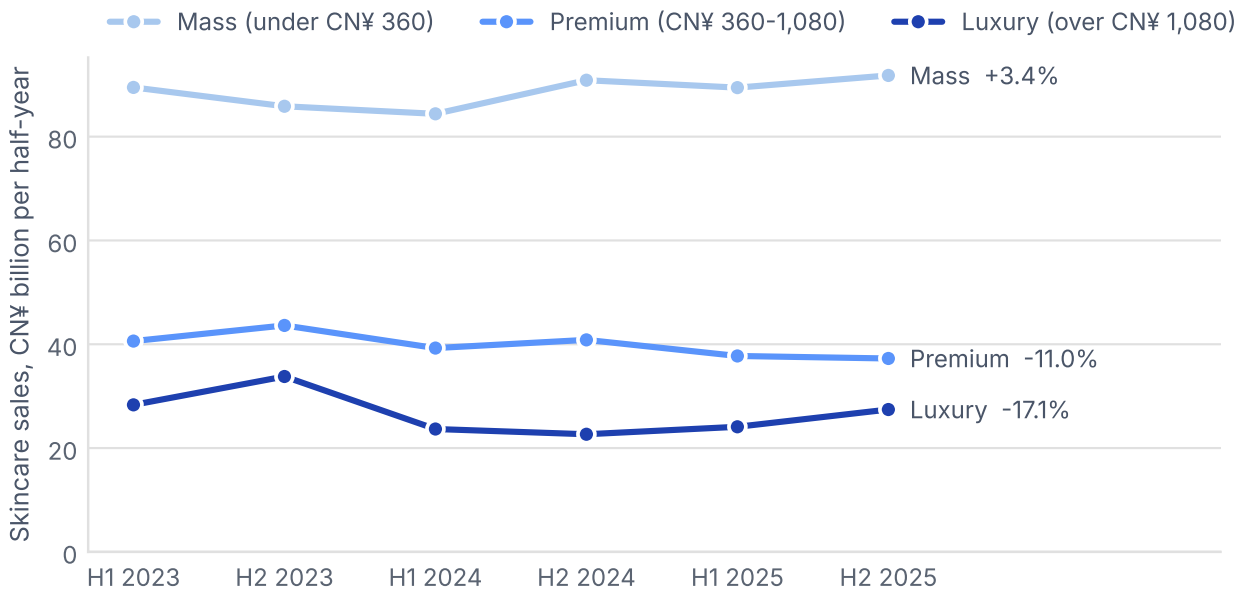
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces. Premium is the CN¥ 360-1,080 unit-price band. US$ at the 2025 annual average of 7.1874 CN¥/US$ (European Central Bank reference rate).

Inside skincare, mass is the only tier that grew

Between 2023 and 2025, mass-priced skincare grew **+3.4%** while the premium band fell **−11.0%** and the luxury band fell **−17.1%**, although luxury has been recovering since its 2024 low. In fragrance, every band grew in 2025, with mass at **+10.6%** and luxury rising fastest at **+49.7%**, while in colour cosmetics premium outgrew mass, which grew **+5.4%**, and the luxury band was essentially flat. We believe the shift in skincare says as much about the rising quality of affordable products as it does about consumer caution.

EXHIBIT 11

Mass skincare grew while premium and luxury fell



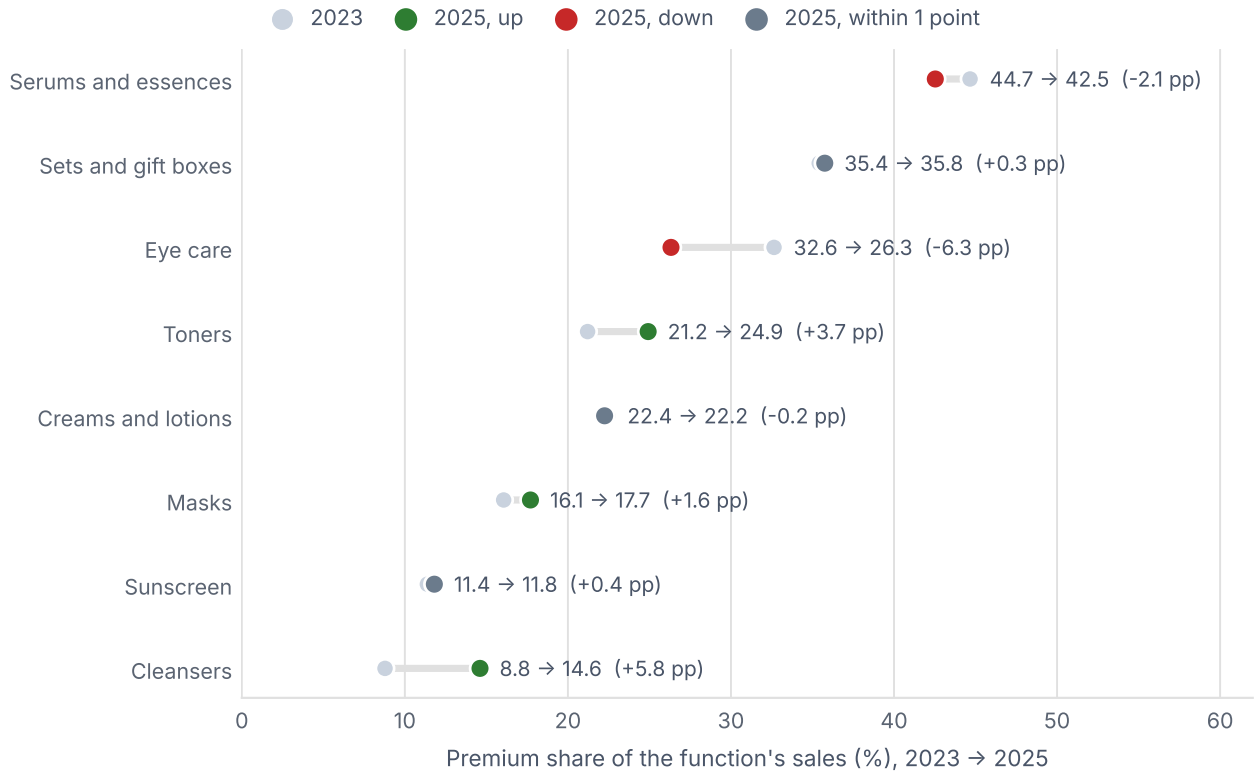
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data, three online marketplaces, skincare sales by price tier and half-year. Mass is under CN¥ 360, premium CN¥ 360-1,080, luxury above CN¥ 1,080; percentages are full-year 2025 against full-year 2023.

Which skincare functions are trading down

Trading down has not been uniform across skincare, and to see where it is happening we matched eight skincare functions node for node across the two established marketplaces, where the category trees line up, and measured the premium share of each function's sales in 2023 and 2025. Three functions account for the decline. The premium share of serums and essences, the largest premium pool, went from **44.7%** to **42.5%**, while eye care, measured across all three marketplaces, fell from **32.6%** to **26.3%**, the steepest drop of any function, and sets and gift boxes held their premium share at ~**36%** while the function as a whole was bought less often, which is a different kind of trading down. Creams and sunscreen were flat and masks edged up, from **16.1%** to **17.7%**, while toners and cleansers traded up overall, with the premium share of toners rising from **21.2%** to **24.9%** and that of cleansers from **8.8%** to **14.6%**, albeit from a low base. These are consolidated figures, and the two marketplaces do not always move together: toners traded up on one and down on the other.

EXHIBIT 12

Serums, eye care and gift sets are trading down, while cleansers and toners are trading up



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data. Premium share of each function's sales, 2023 and 2025, consolidated over the two established marketplaces whose function nodes match; eye care and sunscreen over all three. Functions as classified by each marketplace.

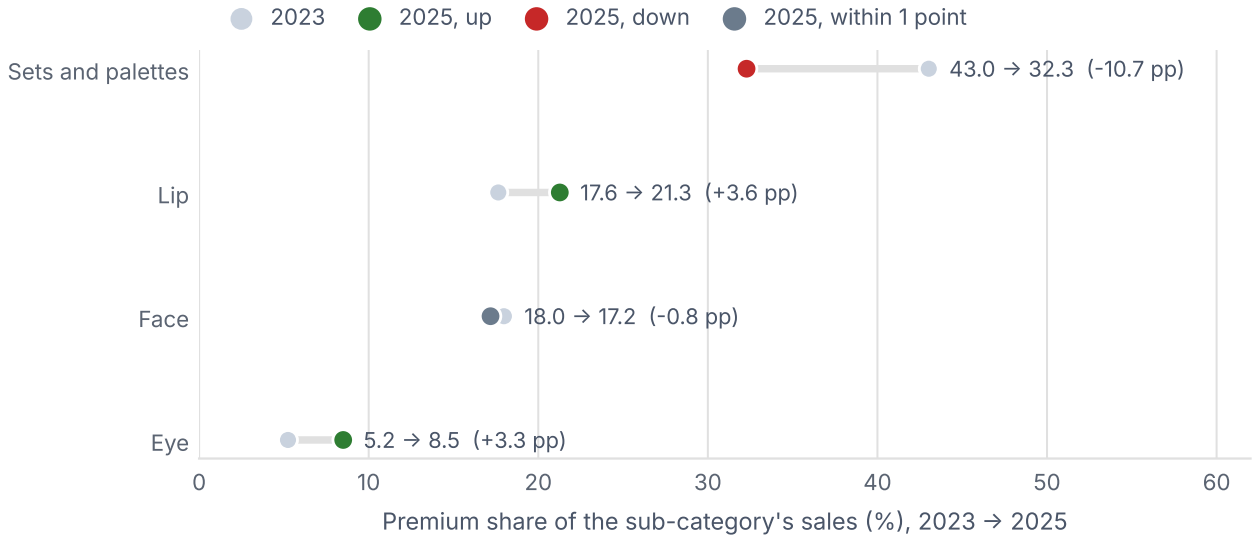
Note: The content-led marketplace's facial-care node is a single bundle before 2025 and is excluded from the function series; its 2025 split is in the appendix.

Lip and eye products are moving up the price ladder, but face products are not

Colour cosmetics went the other way, although not evenly. Across all three marketplaces, the premium share of lip products rose from **17.6%** to **21.3%** and that of eye products from **5.2%** to **8.5%**, while face products, the largest sub-category, stayed at **~17%** overall, a level that nets out opposite moves on different marketplaces, and sets and palettes, measured on the two marketplaces that carry them as a category, fell from **43.0%** to **32.3%** as the sub-category grew at the mass and luxury ends while premium sales fell. We do not break fragrance down any further, since perfume alone makes up **93-95%** of the category on every marketplace.

EXHIBIT 13

Lip and eye moved up the price ladder, while face held and sets and palettes moved down



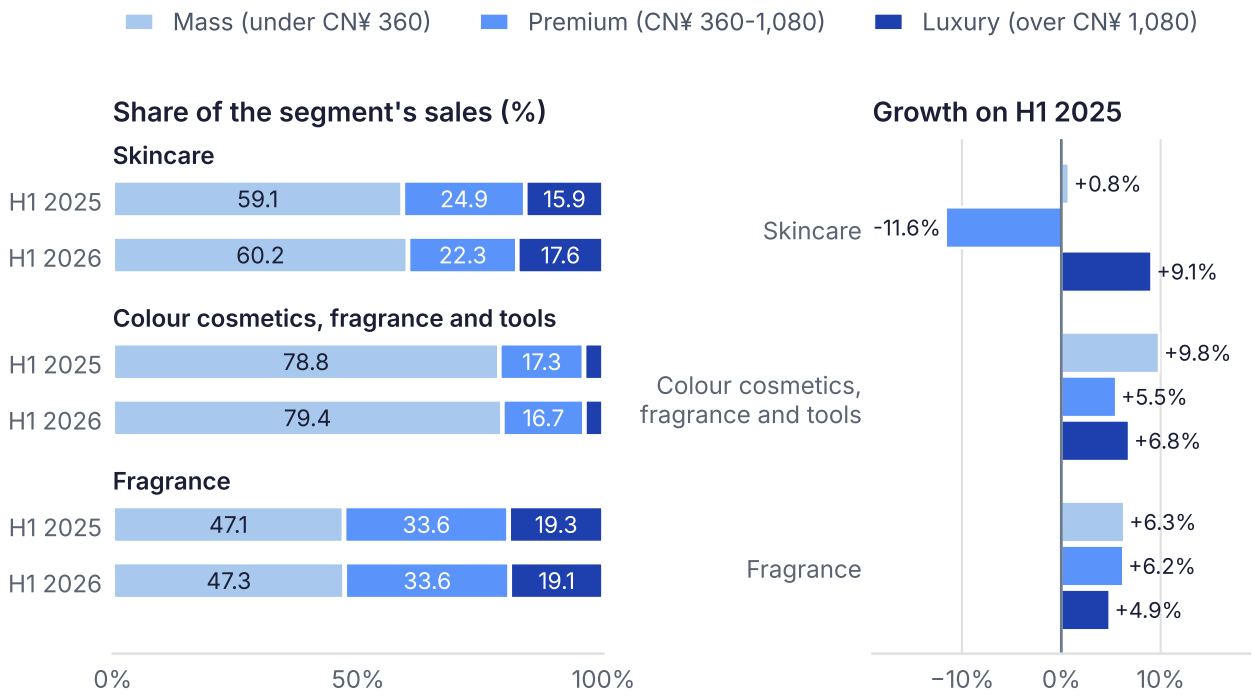
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data. Premium share of each sub-category's sales, 2023 and 2025, consolidated over the three marketplaces; sets and palettes over the two that carry the node. Sub-categories as classified by each marketplace.

The first half of 2026

The first half of 2026 shows the skincare shift going further, and in a new direction. Against the first half of 2025, premium skincare fell **−11.6%**, from **CN¥ 37.7 billion** to **CN¥ 33.4 billion**, while luxury skincare grew **+9.1%**, to **CN¥ 26.3 billion**, and mass skincare held roughly level, so the premium band's share of skincare fell from **24.9%** to **22.3%** as its shoppers moved to either end of the ladder. Measured on January to April alone, before one marketplace restructured its categories, the direction is the same, with premium at **−13.8%** and luxury at **+10.1%**. In colour cosmetics, fragrance and tools, premium grew **+5.5%**, behind the mass tier's **+9.8%**, and in fragrance it grew **+6.2%**, holding its **33.6%** share of the segment.

EXHIBIT 14

In the first half of 2026, premium skincare fell by 12% while luxury skincare grew



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, H1 2025 and H1 2026. Mass is under CN¥ 360, premium CN¥ 360-1,080, luxury above CN¥ 1,080. The middle segment is the marketplaces' own node, which bundles colour cosmetics with fragrance and tools. One marketplace's 2026 series is joined across a category restructure; see the appendix.

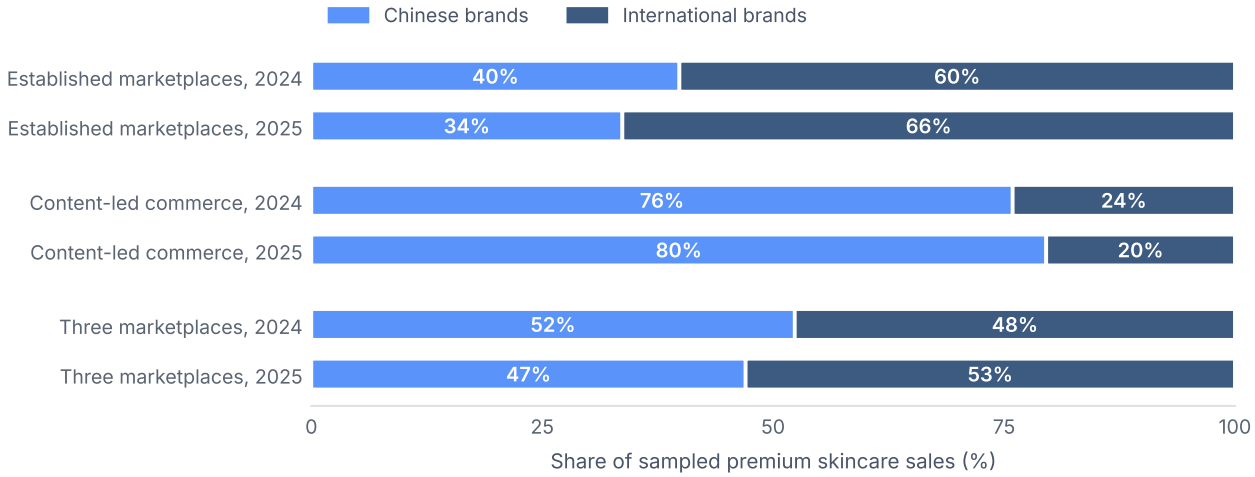
Whose premium it is depends on the channel

The common narrative in the trade is that Chinese brands have taken over the premium tier. We tested this on premium skincare, the largest premium pool, by taking the **500** best-selling skincare items on each marketplace in 2024 and 2025, keeping those priced within the premium band, and classifying the brand behind each one as either Chinese or international, a classification that is our own, with a source recorded for every brand, on a sample that covers between a fifth and a half of premium-band sales depending on the marketplace and year.

The answer depends on where you look. On the established marketplaces, international brands held **60%** of sampled premium skincare sales in 2024 and **66%** in 2025, while on content-led commerce, Chinese brands held **76%** in 2024 and **80%** in 2025, so both channels moved further in the direction they were already heading. Consolidated across all three marketplaces, the split moved from ~**52/48** Chinese to international to **47/53**, but we read that shift as mostly a mix effect, because premium sales in the content-led sample fell as its best-seller list filled up with mass-priced items, which gave the established marketplaces more weight in the total.

EXHIBIT 15

International brands lead sampled premium skincare on established marketplaces, Chinese brands on content-led commerce



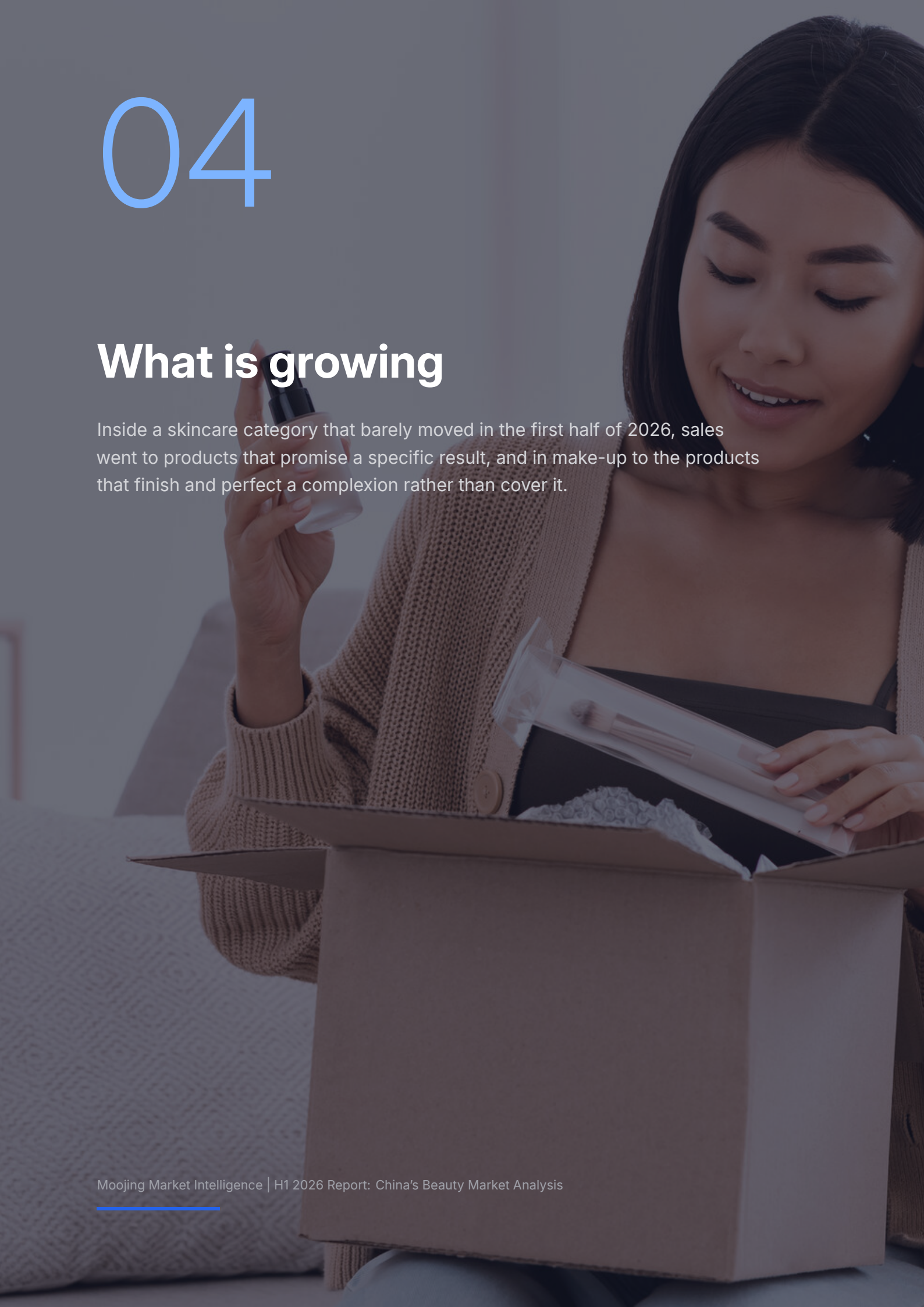
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data. Brand origin of sampled premium skincare sales, 2024 and 2025, as an analyst classification; the sampling is described in the appendix. No brand is named.

Consumers have not stopped buying premium skincare, but they have changed which premium they buy, where they buy it and from whom. For a brand planning its China strategy, we believe this is the most useful way to reframe the question: an international premium brand that is absent from content-led commerce is missing from the channel that now carries more than half of sales, while a Chinese premium brand that sells only there has yet to be tested on the marketplaces where premium is still international.

04

What is growing

Inside a skincare category that barely moved in the first half of 2026, sales went to products that promise a specific result, and in make-up to the products that finish and perfect a complexion rather than cover it.

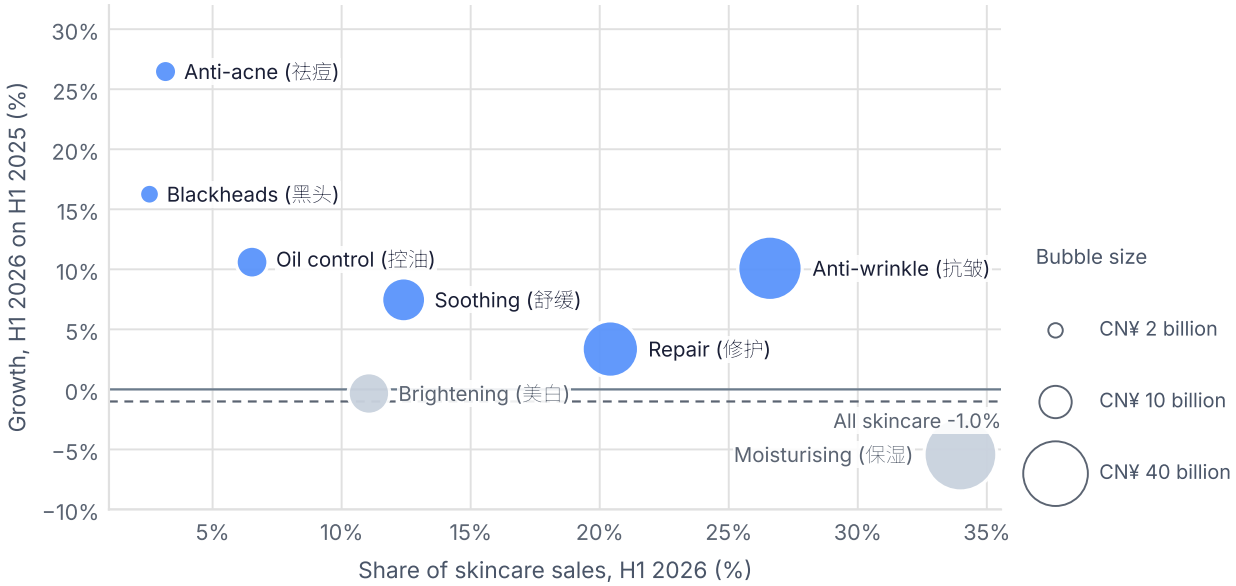


Skincare that promises a result

Our data do not carry a reliable field for what a skincare product claims to do, so to see which claims are growing we measured the sales of skincare products whose titles name a benefit, for eight benefits, across the three marketplaces. A product whose title names two benefits counts under both, so the figures overlap and do not add up to the category, but each one is measured the same way in both years. Skincare as a whole moved **−1.0%** between the first half of 2025 and the first half of 2026, and against that, products sold on an anti-acne claim (祛痘) grew fastest, by **+26.5%**, from **CN¥ 3.8 billion** to **CN¥ 4.8 billion**, followed by blackheads at **+16.3%**, oil control at **+10.6%** and anti-wrinkle at **+10.1%**. Moisturising is still the largest claim by far, on products that took **34%** of skincare sales, but it fell **−5.4%**, while the gentler claims of soothing and repair grew **+7.5%** and **+3.4%**. The keywords are Chinese title words, so a shift in how merchants word their titles could move them too, and we read the ranking rather than the exact rates.

EXHIBIT 16

Anti-acne products grew fastest, by more than a quarter, while moisturising, the largest claim, fell



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, H1 2025 and H1 2026. Sales of skincare products whose titles name each benefit (Chinese keyword in brackets), as a share of all skincare sales and as growth; bubble size is H1 2026 sales. A title can name several benefits, so the figures overlap.

The anti-acne growth is a content-led story. On content-led commerce, sales of anti-acne products rose by about two-thirds, while on the established marketplaces taken together they were broadly flat, at about **CN¥ 2.2 billion** in both halves. We believe the growth is being driven by short-video and livestream selling, in which a visible before-and-after is the whole pitch.

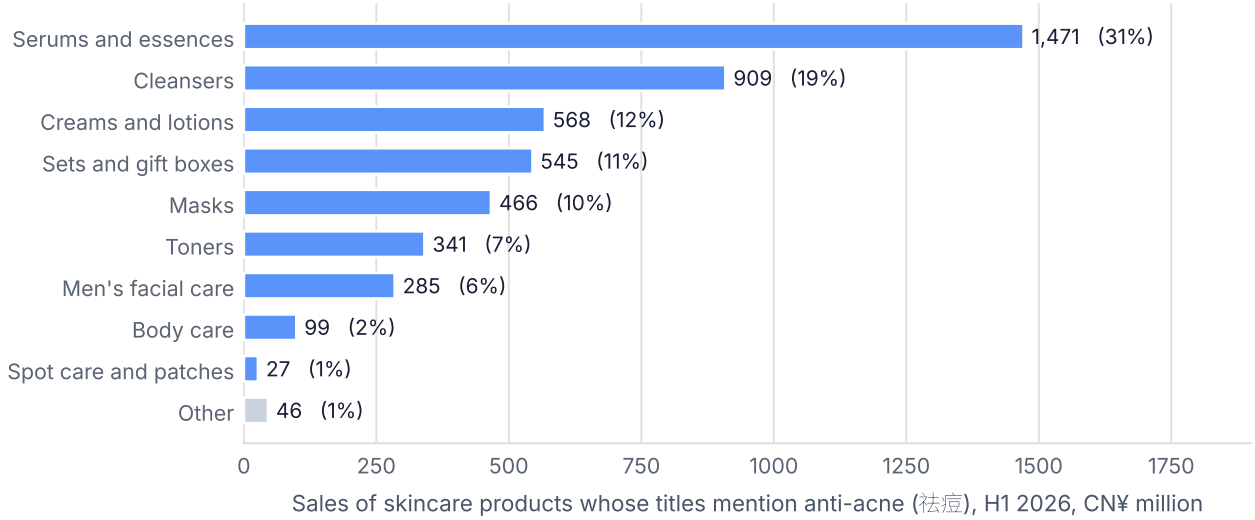
Where anti-acne sales go

By product type, serums and essences carry **31%** of anti-acne sales, at **CN¥ 1.5 billion** in the first half of 2026, followed by cleansers at **19%**, and it is these two, a treatment and a wash, that most anti-acne routines are built around. On the established marketplaces, where both years can be compared type by type, the claim is spreading to smaller types, with anti-acne toners up **+34%**, body care up **+55%** and spot care and patches roughly doubling, although spot care sold only

CN¥ 27 million across the three marketplaces and the body-care rise rests on a small base, while anti-acne cleansers there fell **−9.0%**.

EXHIBIT 17

Serums and cleansers carry most anti-acne sales



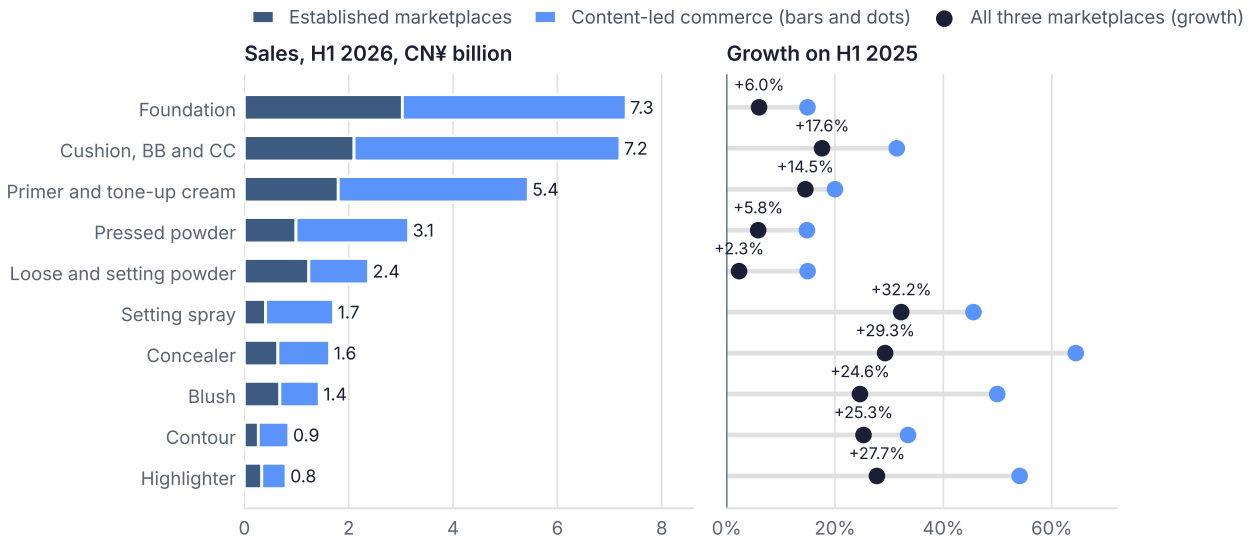
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, H1 2026. Sales of skincare products whose titles mention anti-acne (祛痘), by product type as classified by each marketplace; share of the anti-acne total in brackets. Growth by type is given in the text for the two established marketplaces only, because the content-led marketplace's 2025 facial-care node is a single bundle.

Face make-up that finishes rather than covers

Face make-up grew **+13.6%** across the three marketplaces, from **CN¥ 28.1 billion** in the first half of 2025 to **CN¥ 31.9 billion** in the first half of 2026, and the fastest growth came from the products that set, correct and shape a complexion rather than cover it, with setting spray at **+32.2%**, concealer at **+29.3%**, highlighter at **+27.7%**, contour at **+25.3%** and blush at **+24.6%**. Foundation is still the largest face product at **CN¥ 7.3 billion**, but it grew only **+6.0%**, while cushion, BB and CC products, growing **+17.6%**, are now almost as large. The growth came from content-led commerce, where face make-up grew **+25.6%**, while on the established marketplaces taken together it was slightly down.

EXHIBIT 18

Face make-up grew by 14%, fastest in setting sprays and concealer, and the growth came from content-led commerce



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data across three online marketplaces, H1 2025 and H1 2026. Face make-up categories as classified by each marketplace, matched by name into ten groups; make-up removers, sets, palettes and multi-use products are excluded. One marketplace's 2026 series is joined across a category restructure; see the appendix.

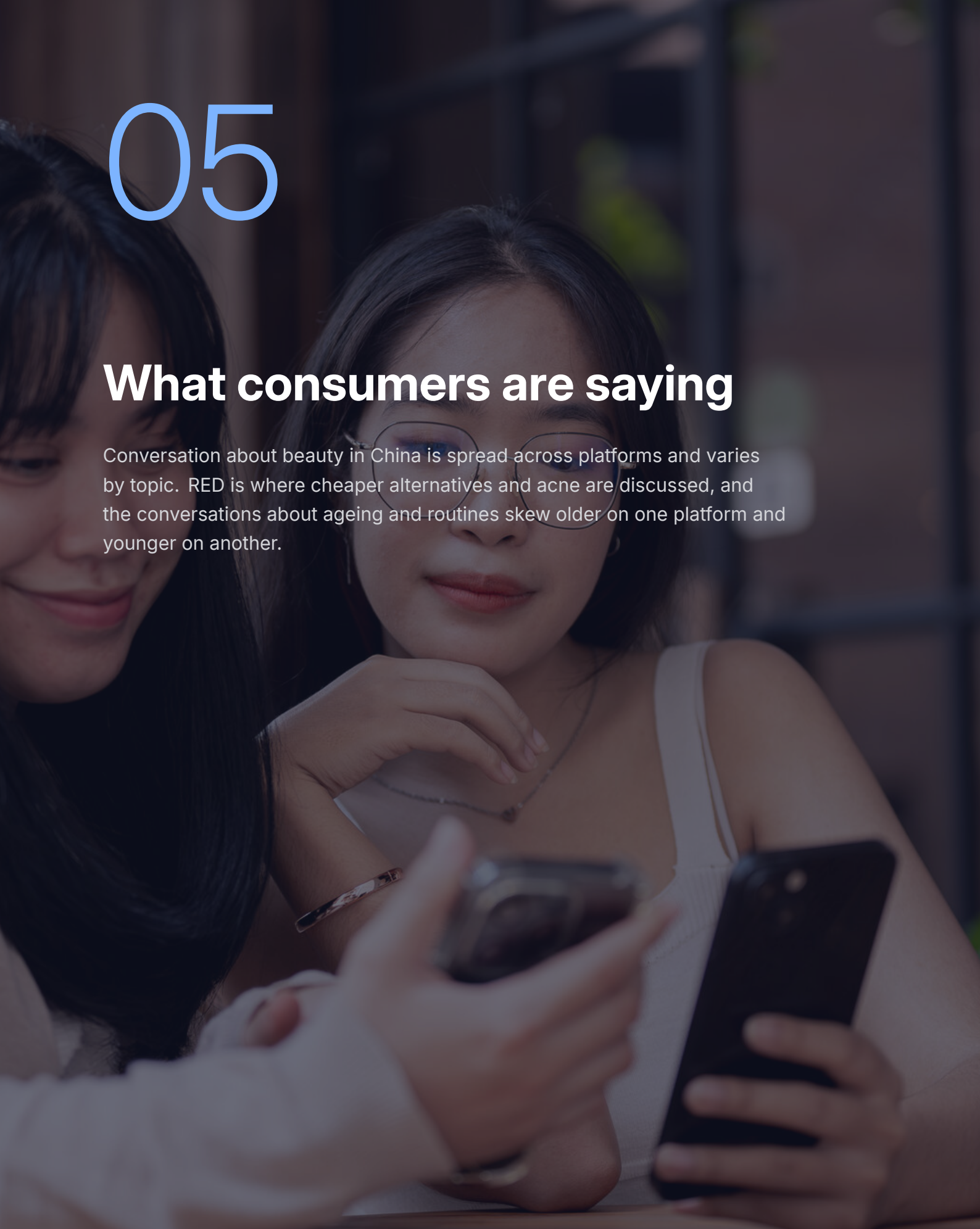
WHAT LAUNCHED IN THE FIRST HALF

The launches of the first half point the same way, towards light, skin-friendly make-up that does a second job. Caitang's Slim Tube Foundation 2.0 promises all-day soft-matte coverage with botanical skincare ingredients, EviDenS's Oxygen Sunscreen doubles as a primer that sits under foundation, NARS's Spring Peach collection brings sheer peach and apricot tones to eyes, cheeks and lips, and Lancôme's Éclat Lip Glaze offers a hydrating, low-saturation nude shine for a no-make-up look.

05

What consumers are saying

Conversation about beauty in China is spread across platforms and varies by topic. RED is where cheaper alternatives and acne are discussed, and the conversations about ageing and routines skew older on one platform and younger on another.



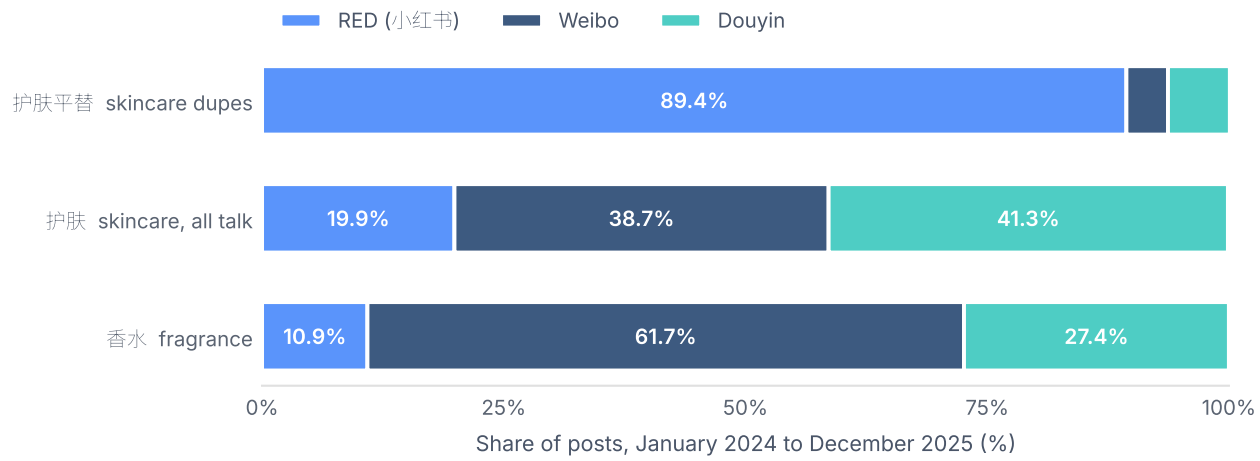
Where cheaper alternatives are discussed

This chapter names social platforms, because it draws on a separate social listening dataset covering Weibo (微博), RED and Douyin (抖音) from January 2024, which counts posts rather than sales and is not a proxy for demand.

Across 2024-2025, RED carried **19.9%** of all skincare conversation across the three platforms, the smallest share of the three, but on the conversation about affordable substitutes for premium skincare, known as 护肤平替 and what the trade calls "dupes", RED carried **89.4%**, a **4.5×** over-index that makes it the centre of value-seeking discovery in the category, although most of that conversation dates from 2025. Fragrance is the mirror image, with RED holding **10.9%** of fragrance conversation and Weibo dominating at **61.7%**, largely on the back of brand and celebrity campaign posts. The dupes conversation is still small but growing quickly, from **627** posts in 2024 to **6,172** in 2025, a growth rate that is directional and should not be quoted as a headline on its own.

EXHIBIT 19

Talk about cheaper substitutes concentrates on RED



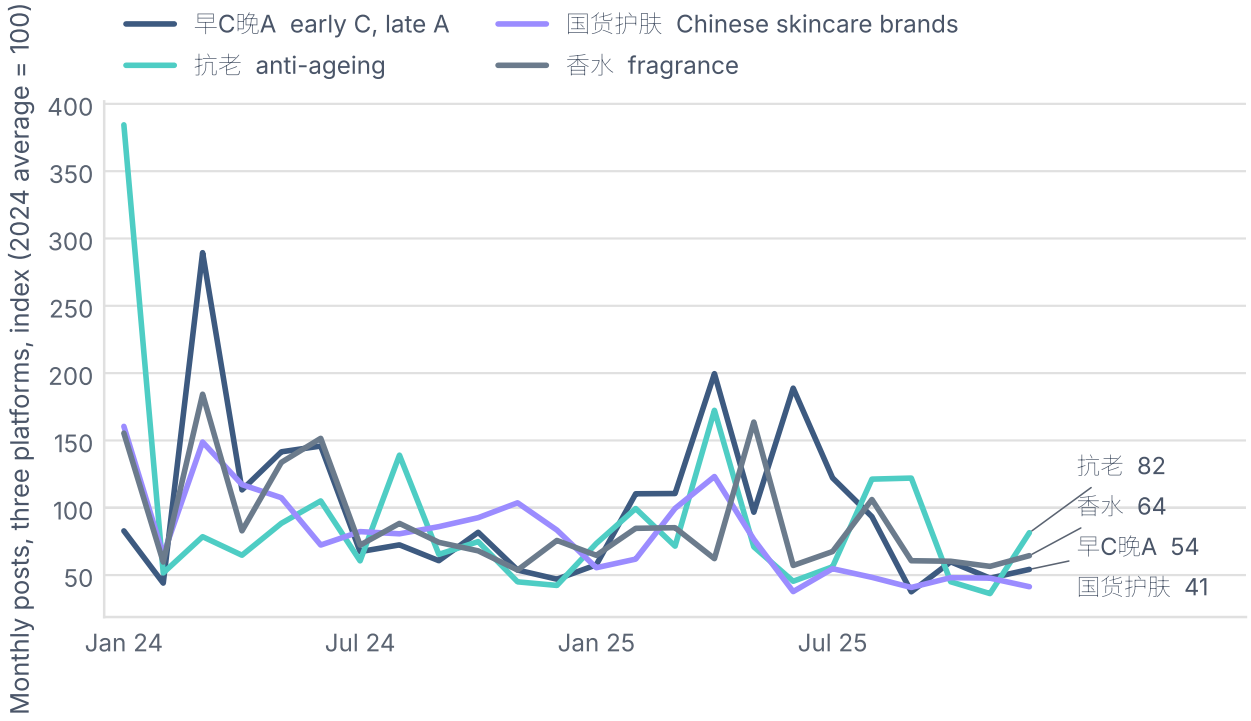
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, social listening across three social platforms, share of posts by platform, January 2024 to December 2025. Conversation volume only; none of these platforms reports sales here.

Four conversations over two years

We also followed four larger conversations through 2024 and 2025: 早C晚A, the routine of vitamin C by day and retinol by night; 抗老, anti-ageing; 国货护肤, Chinese skincare brands; and 香水, fragrance. Indexed to their 2024 average, the routine conversation held at **98** in 2025, while anti-ageing fell to **83**, fragrance to **78** and Chinese-brand skincare to **61**, so the conversation about Chinese skincare brands fell by two-fifths in the same year those brands gained share of premium sales on content-led commerce, which we read as the novelty wearing off rather than the demand.

EXHIBIT 20

Only the routine conversation held its 2024 level



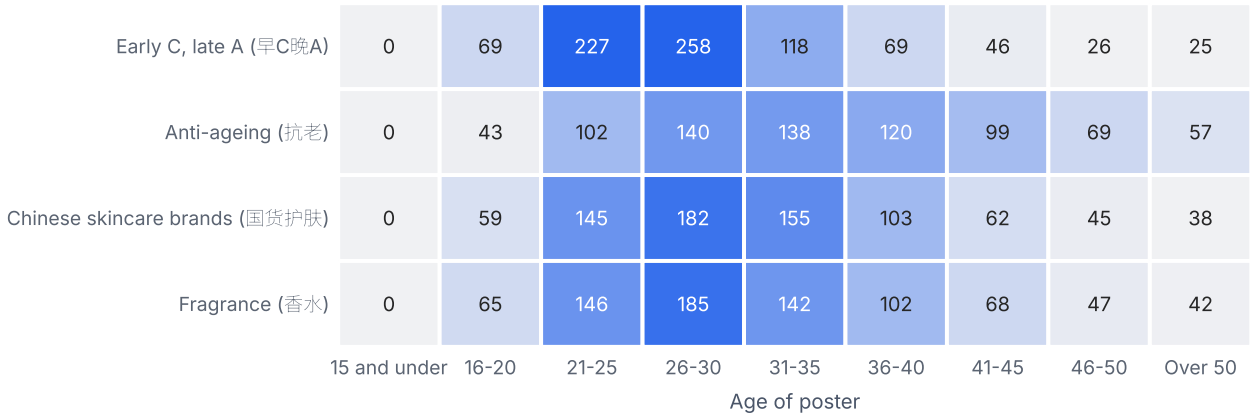
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, social listening across three social platforms, monthly posts indexed to each keyword's 2024 monthly average. 2026 months are not shown because two platforms' 2026 volumes are still filling and are not yet comparable.

Who is talking

Age profiles come from Douyin and Weibo, since RED does not return one. On Douyin, all four conversations peak at ages **21-30**, and the routine conversation is the most concentrated, with a target group index (TGI) of **258** at ages 26-30, meaning that age group is two and a half times as likely to post about it as the platform average, whereas on Weibo the anti-ageing conversation skews the other way, with its TGI rising through the forties to **191** at ages 46-50. Sentiment is overwhelmingly positive, as is typical of beauty conversation, so the more useful reading is the negative share, which is **1.3-2.5%** of classified posts for the three skincare conversations against **8.3%** for fragrance, where campaign-driven volume tends to bring more argument with it.

EXHIBIT 21

On Douyin, every conversation peaks among posters in their twenties



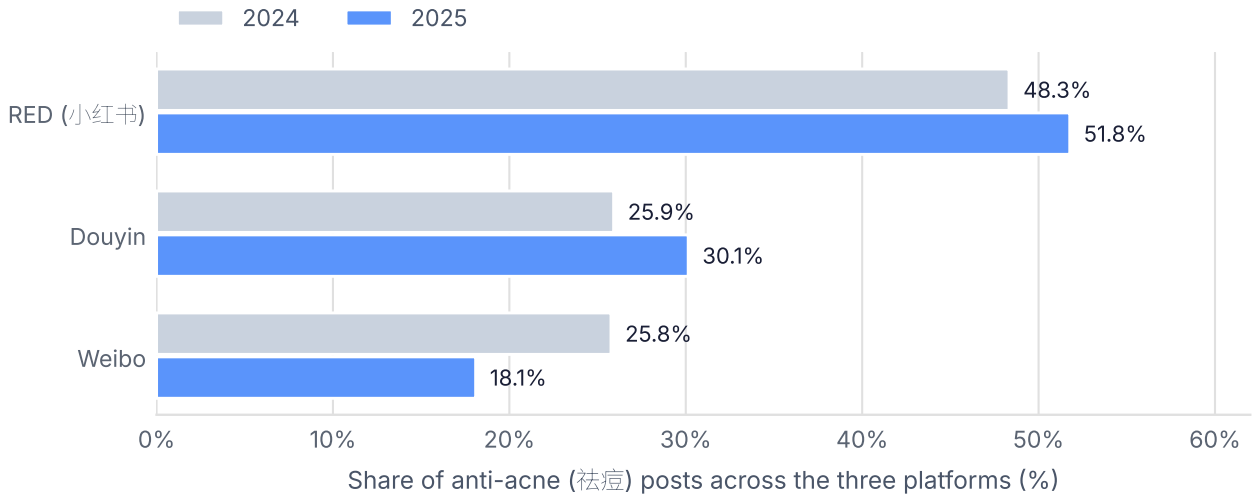
Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, social listening, Douyin, 2025. Age TGI by keyword, where 100 is the platform average.
Note: Douyin returns no posters aged 15 and under. The dupes keyword is omitted because its base is too small.

The conversation about acne

The conversation about acne (祛痘) was a little smaller in 2025 than in 2024 across the three platforms. RED carries half of it, and its share rose from **48.3%** to **51.8%**, while Douyin's share rose fastest, from **25.9%** to **30.1%**.

EXHIBIT 22

Half of the anti-acne conversation is on RED, and Douyin's share is rising fastest



Source: Moojing Market Intelligence, social listening across three social platforms, share of posts mentioning 祛痘 (anti-acne), 2024 and 2025. Conversation volume only.

On Douyin, the people posting about acne are also getting a little younger, although this is one platform only. Between the first half of 2025 and the first half of 2026, posters under 31 went from **38.3%** to **41.4%** of the platform's anti-acne audience, with the 26-30 group rising from **21.0%** to **23.2%**, although posters aged 31-35 remain the largest group, at **25.6%**.

06

2026 outlook and recommendations

Growth has thinned but not stopped, and where it continues depends on segment, channel, calendar and claim, so we set out five recommendations below, each based on the exhibits in this report.



The shape of 2026

Our outlook for 2026 is about the shape of the market rather than a single number. The whole category grew **+1.1%** over the first seven months, about a third of last year's rate, and the trend does not support a reliable projection for the full year, whereas colour cosmetics, fragrance and tools are on a trend the data does support, pointing to growth of between **+2.1%** and **+10.6%**. Inside that slow total, the first half of 2026 rewarded products with a specific job to do, whether an anti-acne serum or a setting spray, and most of that reward went through content-led commerce. We believe 2026 will reward brands for where they position themselves, and for what their products promise, more than for simply being present.

RECOMMENDATION 1 **Time premium launches into the promotional windows**

Premium's share of the category is higher in May, June, October and November in every year we observe, and, averaged over the three years, for every skincare function (Exhibits 8 and 9). Brands should launch and price-anchor premium lines inside the bloc, when shoppers are most willing to upgrade, and plan ahead for the month that follows, when sales in most skincare functions run 20-42% below the April-May run-in after 618 and 18-51% below September-October after Double 11.

RECOMMENDATION 2 **Choose product direction segment by segment**

In skincare, brands should defend their position at mass and mid price points, since that is where the category grew and where cleansers and toners are quietly trading up (Exhibits 11 and 12), and should expect the premium band to keep losing ground at both ends, with luxury skincare growing even as premium falls (Exhibit 14). Serums and eye care are the premium positions to protect, because that is where the premium share is being lost, and gift sets deserve some scepticism now that they are bought less often. In colour cosmetics, the opportunity is to push premium in lip and eye products, where the premium share is rising (Exhibit 13), and in fragrance the whole price ladder is rising, so there is little reason to lead with mass.

RECOMMENDATION 3 **Build for content-led commerce**

Content-led commerce carries 55% of beauty sales and is still gaining share (Exhibit 5), four-fifths of its sampled premium skincare sales go to Chinese brands (Exhibit 15), and it is where the growth in anti-acne skincare and face make-up came from in the first half of 2026 (Exhibits 16 and 18). For international brands the implication is an uncomfortable one, since staying away means missing the channel where the growth is, while being there means competing with Chinese premium brands on their home ground, and for Chinese brands it is the reverse, because the established marketplaces are where premium is still international. The margin question on content-led commerce is a real one, but it is better answered with a considered price architecture than by staying away.

RECOMMENDATION 4 **Treat RED as the value-seeking channel**

Nine-tenths of the conversation about affordable substitutes for premium skincare happens on RED, even though the platform carries only a fifth of skincare conversation overall (Exhibit 19), which makes RED the place where mass and mid-priced skincare is discovered and compared, and a less natural place to expect premium discovery. Brands should seed their mass and mid-priced lines there with that comparison in mind, including the anti-acne products whose conversation RED leads (Exhibit 22), and take premium discovery to the platforms where the routine and anti-ageing conversations take place, matching the age profile to the platform (Exhibit 21).

RECOMMENDATION 5 **Build products around a specific, visible result**

Shoppers in the first half of 2026 spent more on products that name the problem they solve, with anti-acne, blackhead, oil-control and anti-wrinkle claims all outgrowing a skincare category that edged down, while the broad moisturising claim fell (Exhibit 16). Brands should build ranges around one clear result, anchored in the serums and cleansers that carry most of the claim’s sales and extended to toners and body care, where it is spreading (Exhibit 17), and in make-up should favour the products that set and perfect a complexion, such as setting sprays, concealers and cushions, over another foundation (Exhibit 18). A result that can be shown on camera suits the short-video and livestream formats in which these products are selling.

What we will watch in the second half

Four things will decide whether the shape we describe holds through the second half of the year. The first is October, and whether the peak stays there and the promotional bloc keeps its two-fifths share of annual sales, and the second is whether the slowdown in growth reverses in Q4 2026, which the first seven months cannot tell us. The third is the premium mix on content-led commerce, where the share held by Chinese brands rose again in 2025 and where the next round of international premium launches will be tested, and the fourth is whether the growth in result-led skincare and complexion make-up spreads beyond content-led commerce to the established marketplaces, where it has yet to appear.

Appendix: method and limits

ATTRIBUTION AND COVERAGE

Coverage is three of China's largest online marketplaces, monthly, with the commercial series running from 2022, while several other marketplaces sit outside it and offline retail is excluded entirely, so no figure here is the size of China's beauty market. Content-led commerce is represented by one of the three marketplaces and established marketplace commerce by the other two, so channel-type figures for content-led commerce rest on a single marketplace; any other single-marketplace figure is described as such. Some of the questions in Chapter 4 were first raised in Moojing's H1 2026 Beauty & Skincare white paper; the figures in Chapters 3 to 5 that answer them were measured on the three-marketplace scope described here, and no figure is taken from that paper.

SALES AND UNITS

Sales are modelled from observed listings and captured prices, and units are a modelled estimate rather than a platform-audited figure; no external audit exists for any number in this report. Because sales equal units multiplied by captured price, the fact that the two agree shows that the pipeline is consistent, not that the measurement is accurate.

PRICE BANDS AND THE COUPON TEST

Premium is a unit price of CN¥ 360-1,080, applied identically to every segment and marketplace, with mass below it and luxury above. This is our working band rather than an industry standard. Moving it by ±20% does not change the direction of the two findings we tested it on, the premium trend in content-led skincare and the promotional-months gap; the findings new in this edition were not re-tested on other bands. US dollar equivalents use the 2025 annual average of 7.1874 CN¥/US$ (European Central Bank reference rate). One cell of the 324-cell monthly panel differs by 23% between two query shapes, but excluding it does not change any conclusion.

Bands are built on list price without deducting coupons, and the promotional months are precisely when strike-through pricing is everywhere, so an inflated stored price could in principle push items up into the premium band and manufacture the promotional-months finding. We tested this by re-running a Double 11 month with coupons fully deducted (Exhibit 23). Band membership does depend on the price version, with roughly 153,000 units moving down across band boundaries once coupons are removed, but the effect on premium's share is an order of magnitude too small to produce a 4-point gap.

EXHIBIT 23

Deducting coupons moves premium share by less than a fifth of a point

Double 11 month, skincare	Coupons not deducted	Coupons deducted	Change
Premium share of the node	28.66%	28.49%	−0.17 pp
Units in the node	89,910,907	89,910,907	0
Units crossing a band boundary	—	~153,000	downward

Source: Moojing Market Intelligence. One Double 11 month on one marketplace, skincare, re-run with the data version that deducts coupons fully, against the default that does not.

THE PROMOTIONAL-MONTHS FINDING

The promotional bloc is May, June, October and November, the four months that hold ~42% of annual sales in each of the three years. Differences in premium share are tested with a Welch t-test on the monthly shares, comparing the four months against the other eight; the three-year pooled difference is significant at $p < 0.001$, while the single-

year differences are directional. The mix test in Chapter 2 rules out luxury items being re-banded downwards as the mechanism, but it does not establish consumer intent.

The promotional months used to be defined as June and November, the two festival months. On that definition, the premium gap pooled across all three years is +2.5 points, which does not reach statistical significance, and by year it narrows from +5.1 in 2023, when Double 11 still peaked in November, to +0.8 in 2024 and +1.6 in 2025, none of them significant, because since 2024 the Double 11 peak has sat in October and the 618 pre-sale in May. We chose the four-month bloc from the seasonal profile in Exhibit 6 rather than from the test result, and we print the older numbers here so that the choice is visible.

CATEGORY CONSTRUCTS

Skincare, colour cosmetics and fragrance are built as matched segments on each marketplace’s own category tree and applied identically across all three, with tools and nail products excluded from colour cosmetics everywhere. Where the report uses a marketplace’s own bundled category node instead, the exhibit says so. Category trees tend to add nodes over time, so if anything a multi-year decline is understated. Skincare functions (serums, eye care, sets, creams, masks, toners, cleansers and sunscreen) match node for node across the two established marketplaces, but the content-led marketplace’s facial-care node is a single bundle until 2025; its split, available only for November and December 2025, gives premium shares of serums 28.4%, creams and lotions 22.5%, masks 15.5%, toners 15.3% and cleansers 3.6%.

Face make-up in Exhibit 18 is each marketplace’s face make-up node, with its child categories matched by name into ten groups that exist on all three. Where a marketplace combines two products, such as cushion with BB cream or primer with tone-up cream, the groups combine them too. Make-up removers, sets, palettes and multi-use products are left out, because the content-led marketplace’s old and new category structures file them differently.

BENEFIT CLAIMS

The marketplace data does record a product’s claimed benefits, but merchants enter them as free text with several benefits in one field, so the values run to tens of thousands of combinations and do not add up to the category. Chapter 4 therefore measures a claim by the product title instead: for each of eight Chinese keywords (保湿 moisturising, 抗皱 anti-wrinkle, 修护 repair, 美白 brightening, 舒缓 soothing, 控油 oil control, 祛痘 anti-acne and 黑头 blackheads), the sales of skincare products whose titles contain it, on the same skincare construct as the rest of the report, in the first half of 2025 and of 2026. A title that names two benefits counts twice, so the figures are a measure of how much is sold on each claim rather than a split of the category, and a title can use a keyword in passing, which is why the keywords were chosen to be specific. The anti-acne product types in Exhibit 17 are the marketplaces’ own categories, and because the content-led marketplace’s facial-care node was a single bundle in the first half of 2025, growth by type is given for the two established marketplaces only.

We tested the method on three further keywords. Products whose titles mention acne marks (祛痘印) rather than acne itself are a small and shrinking part of the anti-acne figure, at 7% of it in the first half of 2025 and 4% a year later, so the growth is in treatment rather than in fading marks. The alternative word for hydration (补水) fell by more than 保湿 did, which is evidence against the fall in moisturising being merchants changing their wording. Within ageing, the two words move apart: sales on 抗皱 (anti-wrinkle) grew while sales on 抗老 (anti-ageing) fell, and the two taken together grew about 7%, so the anti-wrinkle figure in Exhibit 16 is best read as one word’s share of a larger claim.

THE 2026 SERIES

One marketplace restructured its product categories in May 2026, so its 2026 series has been joined across that change. Because the old and new structures follow on from each other without overlapping, there is no month in which the two can be compared directly, which means the join has been sanity-checked rather than calibrated; we verified it node by node and for continuity in levels. The marketplace’s total is continuous across the change, but the new structure appears to file some products in skincare that the old one filed with colour cosmetics: its skincare growth on the same months a year earlier moves from negative in January-April to positive after the join, while its colour cosmetics growth slows. The whole-category figures are unaffected, but skincare growth after April is somewhat flattered and colour growth understated. For that reason we checked the first-half price-tier findings on January to April alone, where premium skincare fell 13.8% and luxury skincare grew 10.1%, the same direction as the half-year,

while mass skincare, which the half-year puts at +0.8%, was slightly lower, so we describe it as holding level. Figures drawn from this series cover three marketplaces from January to July, or January to June where the exhibit says H1.

PROJECTIONS

Both fits in Chapter 1 are log-linear trends on 45 trailing twelve-month windows ending July 2026, projected five months ahead with a 95% prediction interval. The fit for colour cosmetics, fragrance and tools has an R^2 of 0.93, which is why we quote it, while the whole-category fit has an R^2 of 0.21, which is why we show it but do not quote it.

BRANDS

The marketplace data carries no field for brand origin. For Exhibit 15, we sampled the 500 best-selling skincare items by sales in each marketplace’s skincare category for 2024 and 2025, kept the items whose stored price sits in the premium band (999 items), and classified the brand behind each as Chinese or international by its home country, recording one source per brand. The sample covers 39-41% of premium-band sales on one established marketplace, 49-52% on the other and 22-28% on the content-led marketplace, so the exhibit describes the top of the band and says so. Thirty-three of the sampled brands, mostly small ones selling through content-led commerce, were classified from their regulatory filings alone; all of them have since been checked against public company records, which named a Chinese operating company for thirty-one, left two unsettled, and found no brand with a foreign parent. The two unsettled brands are together worth less than half a point of sampled band sales.

Two of the three marketplaces also record each item’s regulatory filing number, which distinguishes imported products from those registered in China and offers a second lens on origin. It answers a different question, since international brands’ China-made lines carry domestic filings, so we do not blend the two; on that measure, imported products made up 32% of sampled band sales on one established marketplace and 8% on the content-led marketplace in 2025. The brands named in the launch sidebar are there for their products, not their sales, and no brand is named anywhere else in this report.

SOCIAL LISTENING

Social listening, described at the start of Chapter 5, measures posts and interactions; the shares, trend indexes and sentiment figures in this report are computed on posts, and the age index and age shares on posters. Sentiment is scoped to each keyword and is not a measure of market sentiment, and RED returns no age profile. The dupes keyword (护肤平替) has a small base, so its growth is directional, while the fragrance keyword is broad and is used only for share and trend. We read samples of posts for relevance before using any keyword, including 祛痘, and because 2026 volumes on two platforms are still filling, 2026 post counts are not compared with earlier years; the anti-acne audience comparison uses the shares of posters in each age group, on Douyin only, which assumes the filling is spread evenly across ages.

GLOSSARY

Content-led commerce: marketplaces where demand is generated by video, livestream and creator content rather than by search. **Established marketplace commerce**: search-led marketplaces. **Premium**: unit price CN¥ 360-1,080. **Luxury**: unit price above CN¥ 1,080. **Promotional bloc**: May, June, October and November. **Title keyword**: a benefit named in a product’s title, used in Chapter 4 to measure sales by claim. **Buzz** (声量): the volume of social posts on a topic. **TGI**: target group index, a group’s share of posters divided by its share of the platform, times 100. **618**: the mid-year shopping festival. **Double 11**: the November shopping festival, whose pre-sale now sits in October.

MOOJING
Market Intelligence

ABOUT MOOJING

Moojing Market Intelligence turns Asian e-commerce data into decisions for global brands, with extensive brand and category coverage across major marketplaces in Asia and beyond, and a deep historical series behind it. Founded in 2014, with five offices across China plus Kuala Lumpur.

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Lead analyst: Jotham Lim Ee Chen, Global Head of Marketing, Moojing Market Intelligence. Data: Moojing Market Intelligence, observed marketplace data and social listening. Figures rendered with seaborn; set in Inter and Noto Sans CJK SC; built with XeLaTeX. Cover and chapter photography: licensed stock, unrelated to any brand or product discussed in this report. Reference MJ-2026-09-CB, September 2026.

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